

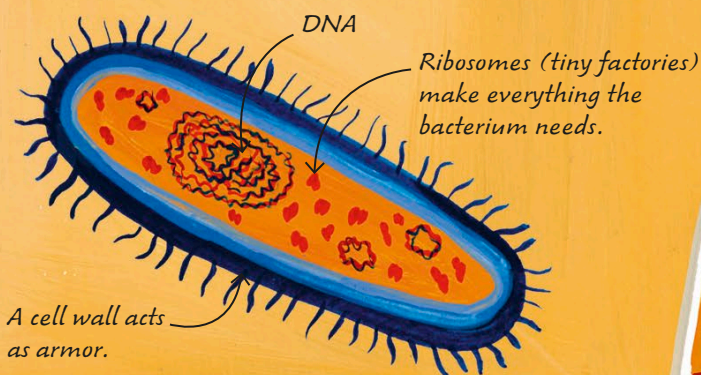


A huge, tiny discovery

Robert realized that this single type of bacteria could be causing anthrax. It was the first time anyone had figured out that a specific type of bacteria caused a certain disease. People could now try to find the bacteria behind other diseases. This would allow them to figure out how to treat, or even prevent, the diseases.

Tuberculosis

In the 1800s, the deadly lung infection tuberculosis (known as TB) was killing a huge number of people each year—and no one knew what caused it. Robert discovered that the germ responsible was this bacillus (rod-shaped bacterium), shown here at thousands of times its actual size.

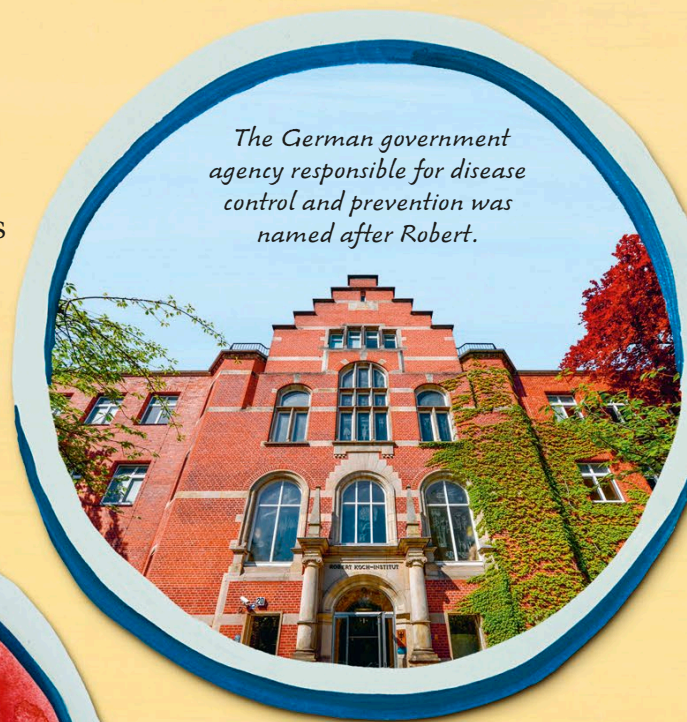


The founder of bacteriology

Robert traveled the world, identifying the bacteria responsible for dozens of diseases, including the biggest killers at the time—tuberculosis and cholera. He passed on his important knowledge, teaching other scientists how to tell bacteria apart. He also helped authorities make plans for preventing infections and controlling large outbreaks, called epidemics.

Once people knew diseases were caused by microbes, they understood how hygiene measures, such as washing your hands and food, could save many lives. Robert was awarded the Nobel Prize in Medicine in 1905.

The German government agency responsible for disease control and prevention was named after Robert.



Cholera bacteria

